Bosnian Crisis of 1908–1909,[22] served to push Russia closer toward Britain.[23] Indeed, the agreement paved the way for a meeting between Edward VII and Nicholas II at Reval in 1908,[24] followed in 1909 with a visit to London by officials of the Duma (a courtesy reciprocated in 1912 by Bernard Pares and other prominent Englishmen).[25] Thus, German ambition, which had been the main impetus behind the creation of the convention, also served to keep it alive.[26] By 1914, Britain and Russia would be at war with Germany and, as Sazonov noted, there was little doubt 'that the agreement of 1907 removed many of the obstacles which might have prevented England from joining Russia in the struggle against Germany'.[27]

Yet therein lay the problem with the convention: it was a 'marriage of convenience', designed to draw Britain and Russia closer together in the face of German ambition.[28] It was not actually concluded in order to resolve the outstanding issues of the Great Game, thus, conflict between the two powers continued well after the signing of that document.[29] Indeed, that Britain and Russia were able to move from a state of such tension in the early 1900s to formal allies in a world conflict by 1914 has tended to obscure the fact that the underlying hostility and suspicion between them never fully abated. This is particularly apparent when one looks at Anglo-Russian interaction in Persia during this period. By the terms of the convention, that country was divided into spheres of influence, with Russia in the north, Britain in the south, and a neutral zone in between – an official recognition of what was already the actual state of affairs in Persia by 1907.[30] Yet, the agreement failed to put to bed the rivalry between the two imperial powers - a rivalry which, as we will see, would revive in the years after the First World War.

The convention was unpopular in both Britain and Russia. Izvolskii was accused by some of being too timid in the negotiations and of renouncing Russia's ambitions in Persia.[31] Meanwhile the British foreign secretary, Sir Edward Grey, came under heavy criticism from all different sectors of British society. Since the Russian sphere contained much of the commercial wealth of Persia, many believed that Britain had received the short end of the straw.[32] The most vocal critic of the convention was Lord Curzon, who characterised it as 'deplorable': 'It gives up all that we have been fighting for [for] years, and it gives it up with a wholesale abandon that is truly